



Ajai Chowdhry receiving Padma Bhushan award from former President, Pratibha D. Patil

for Ajai, as he recalls, “I had a great time in school. I was never a great student but I was fond of doing many things. I used to play table tennis till late evening and I became very good at it. I was number two among the junior table tennis players in the state.” He was also an avid reader and a movie buff.

Ajai took an active part in NCC, which was compulsory in his school those days. He had to go out of the city for NCC activities, which he enjoyed a lot. “I made some very good friends, one of whom, Sharat Saxena, has remained a friend since then. He was my classmate,” he explains.

Ajai remembers being taught by a very sharp mathematics teacher, called *Guruji*, who used to catch hold of Ajai when he couldn’t perform. Ajai also mentions an amazing English teacher, Mr Shinde. He used to teach the language in an

interesting way using theatrical and storytelling techniques. His teaching helped Ajai to get a command over the language.

Ajai completed his schooling in 1966. After that, he attended Jabalpur Engineering College and received a Bachelor of Engineering (Electronics and Telecom) degree in 1971. Later, he did an Executive Program at Michigan where the famous Dr C.K. Prahlad taught him.

Shaping life with great experiences

Fortunately, Ajai was surrounded by family members and friends who helped him to inculcate nice hobbies and interests. For example, Ajai was influenced a lot

by his elder brother, who encouraged him to read different kinds of books. Ajai started with Enid Blyton and went on to Zane Grey, Max Brand, and a whole bunch of western books. Gradually, it became his absolute passion, which continues to date. Ajai’s amazing collection of books is quite enviable.

Ajai remembers going on jungle safaris during his school and college days. He remembers his amazing travel experiences around Jabalpur, such as the elephant safari at Kanha, visiting Marble Rocks on a full moon night, and the boat ride in Narmada near Marble Rocks. Thus, Ajai developed his love for nature and wildlife.

Wildlife photography is also one of his interests. His friend Rajnikanth Yadav helped him a lot to hone his photographic skills. Ajai also posed as a model for Rajnikanth’s photography. One of the pic-

tures was published in *The Illustrated Weekly of India* magazine.

Ajai mentions, “I made friends with one of my neighbours, Chintan Sagreiya, who was a good student. I had another friend, Ashok, who was also a brilliant student. I used to learn a lot from both Ashok and Chintan. Ashok and I got along very well because we both had a strong interest in space science. In those days, my room was full of pictures of space. I used to write to NASA and NASA would very kindly respond and send me huge posters and pictures.”

Ajai reminisces about the day when Armstrong landed on the moon. In those days, television was not yet introduced in India. “The only thing that you had was a basic radio, which you would use somehow to tune to the frequency to get the broadcast from America. Both Ashok and I tuned our radios and listened to the broadcast when Armstrong landed on the moon. My fascination with space has continued since then,” he explains.

Ajai nurtured another great hobby during his college days. He made pen friends around the world. In this pre-email era, his pen-friendship continued with the help of handwritten snail letters. It also helped him to nurture his stamp-collection hobbies. He remembers, “I used to write to my pen friends in the US, France, Germany, Philippines, etc, and used to collect beautiful stamps from their reply to letters. I think, those days, people in these countries had no idea where India was. So, they wanted to know more about India. We always used to wait for letters from our pen friends. And the postman was the most welcome guy to see at home, because he would bring these letters for us.”

This hobby also came into work for Ajai and his friends in some unique ways. For example, as they grew up, they started shaving but the quality of blades available in the country was poor. So, they figured